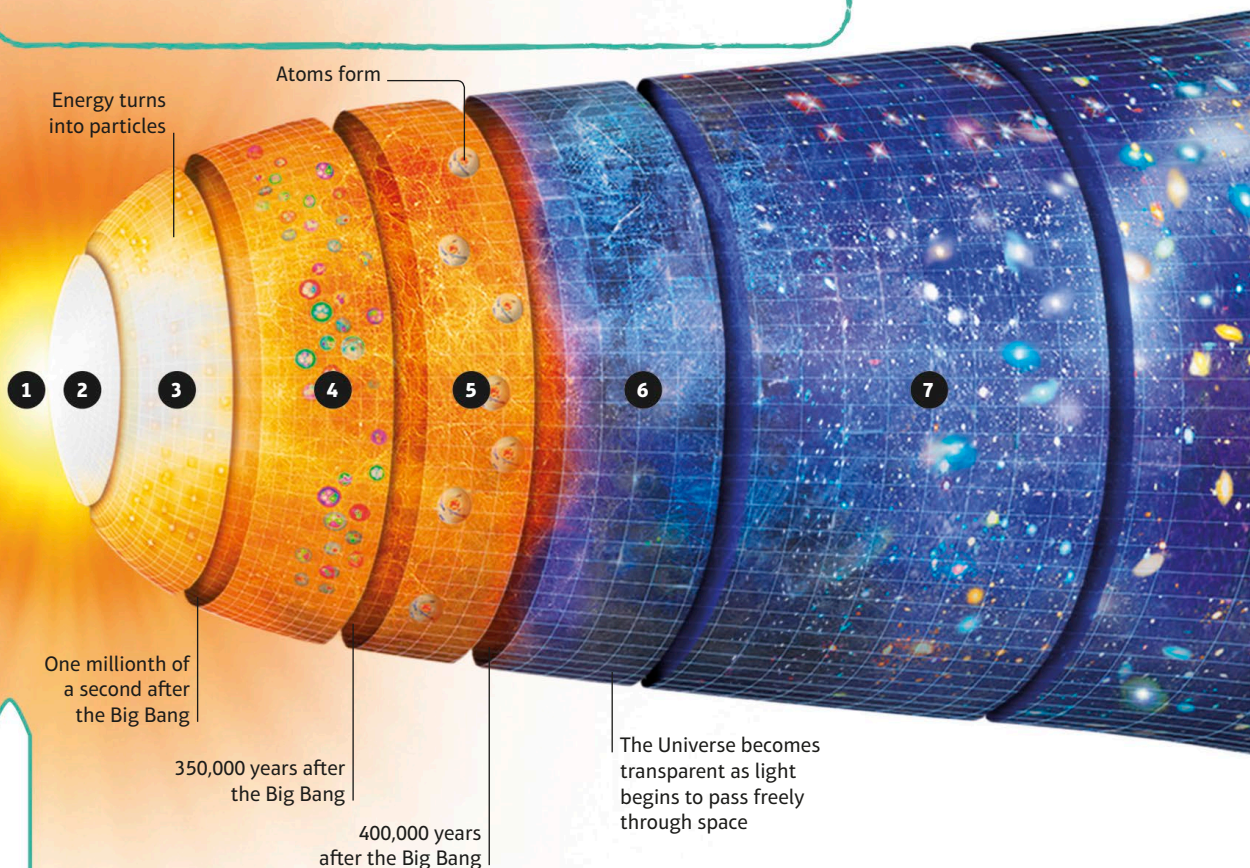


THE BIG BANG

The whole Universe started out **smaller than an atom.**

In the beginning, there was nothing. No stars or planets; no space or time. Then a tiny point of energy appeared. Time began to tick. An instant later, that tiny blob blew up in a vast explosion called the Big Bang that created all the matter in a Universe that continues to expand.



1 A tiny, hot point of energy, smaller than an atom, suddenly appears: astronomers still do not know why the Big Bang happened.

2 In a fraction of a second, the Universe explodes. This period, called "inflation", produces vast amounts of heat energy.

3 At a temperature of trillions of trillions of degrees, the intense heat creates matter and its opposite, antimatter.

4 Matter and antimatter destroy each other. The little matter left over begins to form protons and neutrons.

5 After 380,000 years, the Universe has cooled enough for atomic nuclei to combine with electrons to make hydrogen and helium atoms.